

Phishing Statistics [2026]: Latest Attack Data & Trends

May 2026 • 30 min read • By Nathan House



3.4 billion phishing emails hit inboxes every day — and 82.6% of them are now AI-generated. Whether you need phishing attacks statistics for a board presentation, security awareness training, or your own research, you've found the most comprehensive source available.

I've aggregated **76+ phishing and social engineering statistics** from over 40 authoritative sources — Verizon DBIR, IBM, FBI IC3, CrowdStrike, APWG, KnowBe4, Sophos, and more — and cross-referenced them to produce original analysis you won't find in any single report. You'll find email phishing statistics, AI-powered attack data, click rates by industry, BEC losses, vishing and smishing trends, country targeting, and defense effectiveness across 14 sections below.

Key Phishing Statistics at a Glance

3.4 billion phishing emails sent daily; **82.6%** are AI-generated (Keepnet/VIPRE)

21 seconds — median time to click a phishing link (Verizon DBIR 2025)

\$25 billion in annual global phishing losses (SentinelOne 2026)

\$2.77 billion in FBI-reported BEC losses from 21,442 complaints (FBI IC3 2024)



442% surge in vishing attacks in H2 2024 (CrowdStrike 2025)

54% click rate for AI spear phishing — matching human experts at 95% lower cost (HBR 2024)

36% of all data breaches involve phishing (Verizon DBIR 2025)

<5% phishing susceptibility after comprehensive training (KnowBe4 2025)

Last updated: **May 2026**

3.4B

Phishing
emails/day

82.6%

AI-generated

21 sec

Median click time

\$25B

Annual losses



Key Phishing Numbers (2026)

3.4B

Phishing Emails Sent Daily

Source: AAG IT / industry data

PHISHING LOSSES SINCE YOU OPENED THIS PAGE

\$11.6K

\$295

Per Second

\$17.7K

Per Minute

\$1.06M

Per Hour

Based on \$25 billion annual phishing losses (SentinelOne 2026)

3.4 billion phishing emails are sent every day, making phishing the single largest volume attack vector. APWG tracked 3.8 million phishing attacks across 2025, with Q2 2025 alone recording 1,130,393 attacks. 80,000+ phishing websites are detected annually, each lasting an average of just 12 hours before takedown (BlackBerry 2025). 57% of organisations face daily or weekly phishing attempts (GreatHorn 2025).

Phishing appears in 36% of all data breaches (Verizon DBIR 2025) and is the initial attack vector in 16% of breaches (IBM 2025). 80% of all reported security incidents are phishing-related (CSO

Online). Global phishing losses total \$25 billion annually (SentinelOne 2026), with \$17,700 lost every minute (CSO Online). The FBI IC3 received 193,407 phishing complaints in 2024.

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Phishing emails sent daily	3.4 billion	AAG IT / industry data (https://aag-it.com/the-latest-cyber-crime-statistics/).
Phishing emails that are AI-generated	82.6%	Keepnet Labs / VIPRE Security Group (https://keepnetlabs.com/blog/top-phishing-statistics-and-trends-you-must-know).
Median time to click a phishing link	21 seconds	Verizon DBIR 2025 (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/).
Average phishing click rate	2.7%	Verizon DBIR 2025 (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/).
Phishing in data breaches	36%	Verizon DBIR 2025 (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/).
Phishing as initial breach vector	16%	IBM Cost of a Data Breach Report 2025 (https://www.ibm.com/reports/data-breach).
Security incidents that are phishing	80%	CSO Online (https://www.csoonline.com/article/519878/phishing-statistics.html).
Lost to phishing every minute	\$17,700	CSO Online (https://www.csoonline.com/article/519878/phishing-statistics.html).
Annual global phishing losses	\$25B	CDNetworks / SentinelOne (https://www.sentinelone.com/cybersecurity-101/cybersecurity/cyber-security-statistics/).
FBI IC3 phishing complaints (2024)	193,407	FBI Internet Crime Report 2024 (https://www.ic3.gov/AnnualReport/Reports/2024_IC3Report.pdf).
Phishing attacks tracked annually	3.8 million	APWG Phishing Activity Trends (https://apwg.org/trendsreports/).
Phishing scams reported (Q4 2024)	989,123	APWG Phishing Activity Trends Q4 2024 (https://apwg.org/trendsreports/).
Phishing attacks (Q2 2025)	1,130,393	APWG Phishing Activity Trends Q2 2025 (https://apwg.org/trendsreports/).
Orgs seeing daily/weekly	57%	GreatHorn (https://www.greathorn.com/blog/phishing-statistics/).

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
phishing		
Phishing websites detected (+22% YoY)	80,000+	Group-IB 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).

The Phishing Firehose

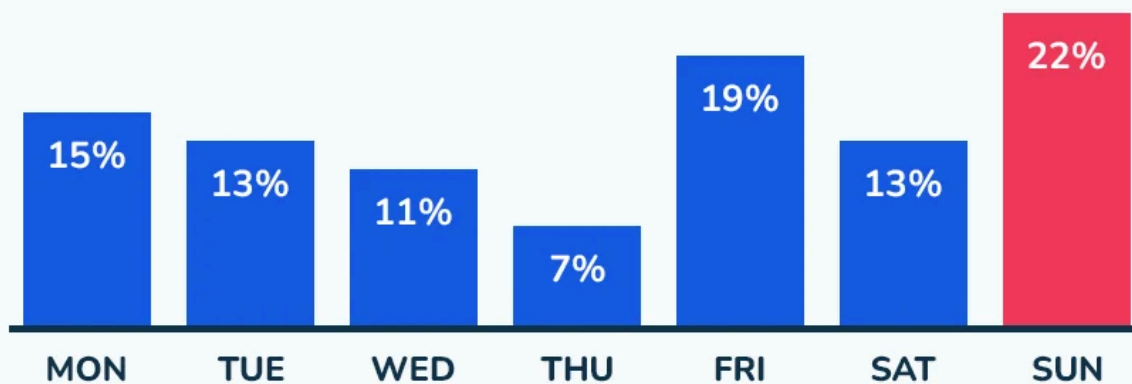
Approximately 39K per second of phishing emails are sent every second. That's 39K per second — enough to fill a 70,000-seat stadium with phishing emails in under two seconds. (AAG IT / industry data)

Phishing at a Glance: The Numbers That Matter

Every 39,000 phishing emails per second, every 92 million clicks per day, every \$17,700 lost per minute — these numbers describe an industrial-scale operation. Phishing is no longer the domain of lone operators sending badly spelled emails from Nigerian princes. It is a professional, AI-augmented industry with specialised roles: access brokers who sell compromised credentials, campaign operators who design and distribute phishing emails, cashout teams who convert stolen data into money, and ransomware groups who use phishing as an entry point for multi-million-dollar extortion.

The professionalisation of phishing is reflected in the infrastructure. Phishing-as-a-Service (PhaaS) kits are sold on dark web marketplaces, complete with email templates, credential-harvesting landing pages, evasion techniques, and customer support. These kits lower the technical bar even further — an attacker with no coding ability can launch a sophisticated phishing campaign for under \$100.

When Are Phishing Emails Sent?



STATIONX

Phishing Is the #1 Breach Entry Point

Cross-referencing IBM (16% initial vector), Verizon (36% of breaches), and CSO Online (80% of incidents), phishing appears in some form across the majority of all security events. When you add BEC (27% of Arctic Wolf incidents) and social engineering (98% of attacks, Sprinto), the picture is clear: phishing is not just a threat category — it's the primary gateway to every other attack type.



How Many Phishing Emails Are Sent Daily?

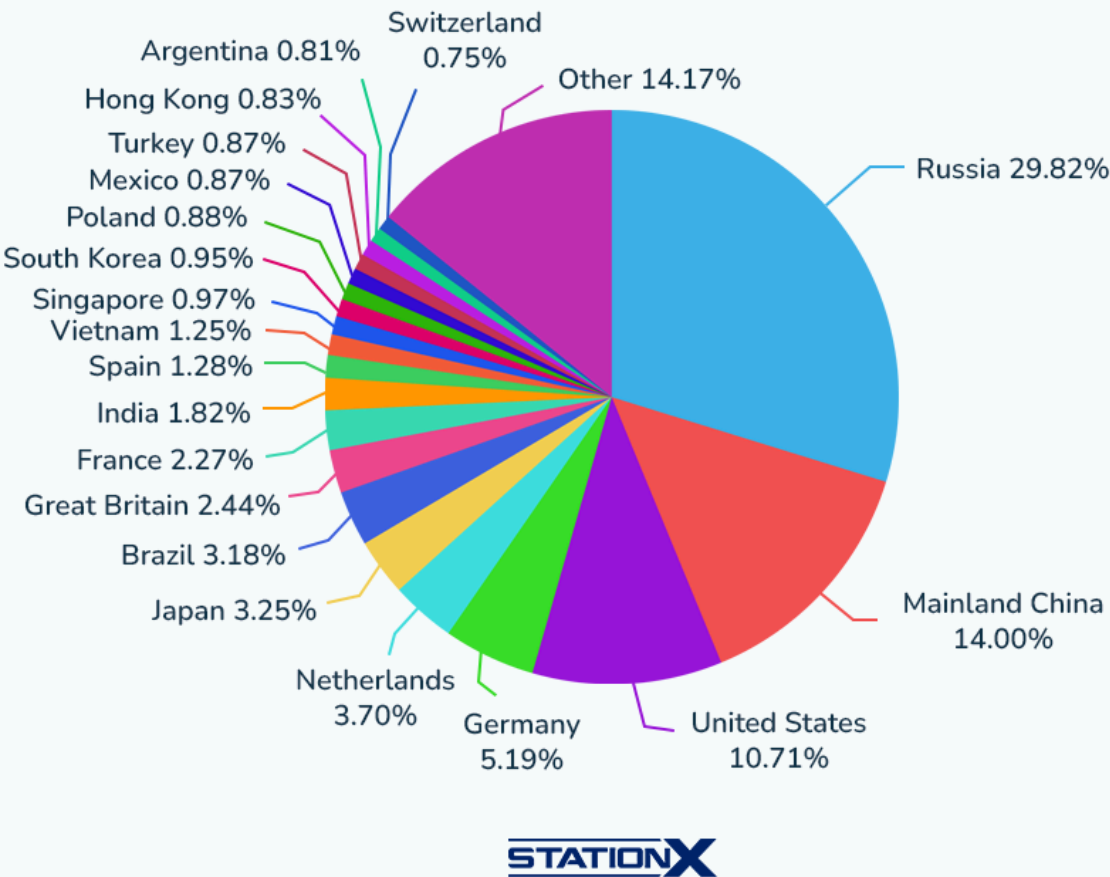
PHISHING WEBSITES DETECTED

80,000+ ^ +22% YoY

The scale of phishing is staggering. 3.4 billion phishing emails flood inboxes daily — that's approximately 39,000 per second. APWG tracked 3.8 million phishing attacks in 2025, with Q2 alone recording over 1.1 million. Phishing websites detected rose 22% year-over-year to 80,000+ (Group-IB 2025), though the average site lasts only 12 hours before takedown (BlackBerry 2025).

Phishing emails peak on Sundays (22% of weekly volume) and Fridays (19%), suggesting attackers time campaigns for when recipients are less vigilant (StationX analysis). 86% of malicious spam uses embedded links rather than attachments (VIPRE 2024), reflecting a shift toward credential-harvesting landing pages.

Source Countries



FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Phishing emails sent daily worldwide	3.4 billion	AAG IT / industry data (https://aag-it.com/the-latest-cyber-crime-statistics/).
Phishing attacks tracked (annual)	3.8 million	APWG Phishing Activity Trends (https://apwg.org/trendsreports/).
Phishing scams (Q4 2024)	989,123	APWG Phishing Activity Trends Q4 2024 (https://apwg.org/trendsreports/).
Phishing attacks (Q2 2025)	1,130,393	APWG Phishing Activity Trends Q2 2025 (https://apwg.org/trendsreports/).
Phishing websites detected	80,000+	Group-IB 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).
Average phishing site lifespan	12 hours	BlackBerry Global Threat Intelligence 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Orgs facing daily/weekly phishing	57%	GreatHorn (https://www.greathorn.com/blog/phishing-statistics/)
Peak phishing day (Sunday)	22%	StationX / Industry data (https://www.stationx.net/cybercrime-statistics/)
Friday phishing share (2nd highest)	19%	StationX / Industry data (https://www.stationx.net/cybercrime-statistics/)
Malspam using links vs attachments	86%	VIPRE Security Group Q2 2024 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/)

\$1.06M Lost to Phishing Every Hour

At \$17,700 per minute (CSO Online), phishing drains \$1.06M per hour and \$25.5M per day from the global economy. That's \$25 billion annually — making phishing alone costlier than most countries' entire cybercrime losses.

Phishing Volume Trend

The trajectory is clear: phishing volume has grown every year for the past decade. APWG's data shows phishing attacks rising from approximately 1 million in 2020 to 3.8 million in 2025. The proliferation of AI tools has accelerated this growth — generating convincing phishing emails at scale requires minimal human effort when large language models handle the writing, personalisation, and translation.

The 12-hour average phishing site lifespan (BlackBerry 2025) reflects both improving takedown capabilities and attacker adaptation. Modern phishing campaigns use disposable infrastructure — spinning up hundreds of sites simultaneously, knowing most will be taken down quickly. The sites that survive even a few hours capture enough credentials to justify the cost, especially when the average click time is just 21 seconds from email delivery.

Why Sundays and Fridays?

Phishing emails peak on Sundays (22%) and Fridays (19%) for strategic reasons. Sunday campaigns exploit reduced IT staffing and weekend inboxes — recipients checking email casually on personal devices are less likely to scrutinise sender addresses or hover over links. Friday campaigns target end-of-week fatigue, when employees rush through overflowing inboxes before the weekend. Thursday (7%) sees the lowest phishing volume, possibly because mid-week alertness is highest.



AI-Powered Phishing

AI-Generated Phishing Emails

82.6% / 100%



82.6% of phishing emails detected between September 2024 and February 2025 utilised AI (Keepnet/VIPRE). AI-automated spear phishing achieves a 54% click-through rate — matching skilled human attackers — while reducing campaign costs by 95%+ (HBR 2024). 37% of breaches now involve AI-generated phishing as the attack method (IBM 2025). 40% of BEC emails in Q2 2024 were identified as AI-crafted (VIPRE 2024).

80%+ of social engineering activity is now powered by AI (Abnormal Security 2025). The convergence of generative AI with phishing has fundamentally changed the economics of attacks: campaigns that previously required days of research per target can now be automated across thousands of targets simultaneously, with personalised content that exploits publicly available information from LinkedIn, social media, and corporate websites.

How AI Changed the Economics of Phishing

Before generative AI, a targeted spear phishing campaign required a human attacker to research each target individually — reading their LinkedIn profile, identifying colleagues, mimicking writing styles, and crafting a personalised email. This took hours per target, limiting attacks to high-value individuals. AI has collapsed this cost to near zero: a single operator can now generate thousands of personalised spear phishing emails per hour, each tailored to the recipient's role, company, and recent activity.

The 95%+ cost reduction (HBR 2024) means phishing campaigns that previously required dedicated criminal teams costing \$50,000+ per operation can now be run for under \$5. The barrier to entry has dropped so far that even unsophisticated actors can launch highly effective attacks. The result: 82.6% of detected phishing emails now show signs of AI generation (Keepnet/VIPRE 2025), and the trend is accelerating.

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Phishing emails utilizing AI	82.6%	Keepnet Labs / VIPRE Security Group (https://keepnetlabs.com/blog/top-phishing-statistics-and-trends-you-must-know).
AI spear phishing click rate	54%	Harvard Business Review / Heiding, Schneier et al. (https://hbr.org/2024/05/ai-will-increase-the-quantity-and-quality-of-phishing-scams).
AI phishing cost reduction vs manual	95%+	Harvard Business Review / Heiding, Schneier et al. (https://hbr.org/2024/05/ai-will-increase-the-quantity-and-quality-of-phishing-scams).

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
BEC emails that are AI-generated	40%	VIPRE Security Group Q2 2024 (https://keepnetlabs.com/blog/top-phishing-statistics-and-trends-you-must-know).
AI phishing as attacker method	37%	IBM Cost of a Data Breach Report 2025 (https://www.ibm.com/reports/data-breach).
Social eng powered by AI	80%+	Abnormal Security / Xceedance (https://www.sentinelone.com/cybersecurity-101/cybersecurity/cyber-security-statistics/).

AI Matches Human Experts at 20x Lower Cost

AI-automated spear phishing achieves a 54% click-through rate — matching skilled human attackers — while reducing campaign costs by 95%+ (HBR 2024). At scale, AI can generate personalised phishing emails for thousands of targets simultaneously, something previously requiring dedicated human operators per target.

54%

AI Phishing Click Rate
matches human experts

95%+

Cost Reduction
vs manual campaigns

37%

AI as Attack Method
of breaches (IBM)

AI Phishing Detection Challenges

Traditional phishing detection relied on identifying tell-tale signs: grammatical errors, suspicious sender addresses, mismatched URLs, and generic greetings. AI-generated phishing emails eliminate most of these signals. The prose is grammatically perfect, culturally appropriate, and personalised to the recipient. AI tools can generate phishing emails in any language with native-level fluency, enabling attackers to target regions that were previously protected by language barriers.

Security vendors are responding with AI-based detection — using machine learning to identify subtle patterns in email headers, sending behaviour, and content that distinguish AI-generated phishing from legitimate communications. But this is an arms race: as detection improves, attackers adapt their generation techniques. The 82.6% AI-generated figure (Keepnet/VIPRE 2025) suggests attackers currently have the upper hand in this race.

The AI Phishing Arms Race

Attackers use AI to generate phishing. Defenders use AI to detect it. But at 82.6% AI-generated email volume and a 54% click rate, the current balance favours attackers. The

defensive advantage lies in phishing-resistant MFA and user training — controls that work regardless of email quality.



How Many People Fall for Phishing Scams?

AVERAGE PHISHING CLICK RATE



The average phishing email click rate is 2.7% (Verizon DBIR 2025). That sounds low — until you multiply it by 3.4 billion daily emails. The result: approximately 92 million successful clicks per day, each a potential breach entry point. The median time to click is just 21 seconds from delivery (Verizon DBIR 2025).

The median time to report a phishing email is 28 minutes (Verizon DBIR 2025) — giving attackers a 27.6-minute head start between the first click and the first alert. 60% of phishing incidents involve identity-based attacks (Cisco 2025), where stolen credentials provide immediate access to systems. After comprehensive security awareness training, phishing susceptibility drops to under 5% (KnowBe4 2025).

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Median time to click phishing link	21 seconds	Verizon DBIR 2025 (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/).
Average phishing click rate	2.7%	Verizon DBIR 2025 (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/).
Median time to report phishing	28 minutes	Verizon DBIR 2025 (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/).
AI phishing click rate (matches human)	54%	Harvard Business Review / Heiding, Schneier et al. (https://hbr.org/2024/05/ai-will-increase-the-quantity-and-quality-of-phishing-scams).
Susceptibility after training	<5%	KnowBe4 Financial Sector Threats Report 2025 (https://www.knowbe4.com/press/knowbe4-report-reveals-global-financial-sector-faces-unprecedented-cyber-threat-surge).

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Identity-based phishing incidents	60%	Cisco Cybersecurity Readiness Index 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/)

92 Million Clicks Per Day

3.4 billion daily phishing emails × 2.7% click rate = approximately 91.8M successful phishing clicks per day. Each click is a potential breach entry point — and it takes just 21 seconds for the first victim to click. (AAG IT / industry data, Verizon DBIR 2025)

27.6-Minute Head Start for Attackers

The median time to click a phishing link is 21 seconds, but the median time to report it is 28 minutes (Verizon DBIR 2025). That gives attackers a 27.6-minute window between the first compromise and the first alert — long enough to move laterally, exfiltrate data, or deploy ransomware.

The 21-Second Problem

21 seconds. That's the median time from phishing email delivery to the first click (Verizon DBIR 2025). To put this in perspective: most security teams cannot even generate an alert in 21 seconds, let alone respond to one. By the time an email security gateway flags a suspicious message for review, the first victim has already clicked, entered credentials, and potentially handed over access to the entire organisation.

The 28-minute reporting gap makes this worse. If the first click happens at 21 seconds and the first report happens at 28 minutes, attackers have a 27.6-minute window of undetected access. In that window, automated attack frameworks can harvest credentials, move laterally through the network, exfiltrate sensitive data, or deploy ransomware. The solution is not just faster detection — it's pre-click prevention through email filtering, URL sandboxing, and phishing-resistant MFA that limits the damage even when users click.

Countries Targeted

Country	Number of Emails	Percentage
Netherlands	68,908,098	17.6777%
Russia	53,211,482	13.6509%
Moldova	27,192,790	6.9760%
USA	24,135,668	6.1918%
Thailand	21,935,110	5.6272%
China	14,574,632	3.7390%
Germany	13,486,816	3.4599%
Great Britain	11,394,190	2.9231%
India	11,311,772	2.9019%
Vietnam	11,231,432	2.8813%
Other Countries	2,157,990	0.5536%



Phishing Type Explorer

Select a phishing type to see its key statistics and characteristics.

Email Phishing

Spear Phishing

Vishing

Smishing

Mass-distributed emails impersonating trusted brands or contacts. The most common phishing vector — responsible for the majority of initial breach access.

DAILY VOLUME

3.4 billion emails

AI-GENERATED SHARE

82.6%

CLICK RATE

2.7%

TIME TO CLICK

21 seconds



Business Email Compromise & Social Engineering

\$2.77B

FBI BEC Losses (2024)

21,442 complaints filed

Business email compromise (BEC) caused \$2.77 billion in FBI-reported losses from 21,442 complaints in 2024 (FBI IC3). The average BEC attack costs \$4.67 million (IBM 2025), making it one of the most expensive phishing variants. BEC accounts for 58% of financially motivated phishing breaches (Verizon DBIR 2025) and 27% of all investigated incidents (Arctic Wolf 2025). BEC volume surged 54% in H1 2025 compared to 2023 (Abnormal Security).

Social engineering is the foundation of nearly all cyberattacks. 98% of attacks involve social engineering in some form (Sprinto). 42% of organisations cite phishing and social engineering as their top cyber risk (WEF 2025). 68% of cyberattacks originate from email (KnowBe4 2025). Pretexting accounts for 50%+ of social engineering incidents, and 90% of Q1 2024 attacks involved social engineering (Avast).

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
FBI BEC losses (2024)	\$2.77B	FBI Internet Crime Report 2024 (https://www.ic3.gov/AnnualReport/Reports/2024_IC3Report.pdf)
FBI BEC losses (2023)	\$2.9B	FBI Internet Crime Report 2023 (https://www.ic3.gov/AnnualReport/Reports/2023_IC3Report.pdf)
Average BEC attack cost	\$4.67M	IBM / HoxHunt (https://www.vikingcloud.com/blog/cybersecurity-statistics)
BEC share of financial breaches	58%	Verizon DBIR 2025 (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/)

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
BEC share of all incidents	27%	Arctic Wolf Threat Report 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/)
Average BEC loss per incident	\$160,000+	Arctic Wolf Threat Report 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/)
BEC volume surge (H1 2025 vs 2023)	54%	Abnormal Security (https://secureframe.com/blog/social-engineering-statistics/)
Social eng share of all attacks	98%	Sprinto / Purplesec (https://www.vikingcloud.com/blog/cybersecurity-statistics/)
Orgs citing phishing/social eng as top risk	42%	WEF Global Cybersecurity Outlook 2025 (https://reports.weforum.org/docs/WEF_Global_Cybersecurity_Outlook_2025.pdf)
Cyberattacks originating from email	68%	KnowBe4 Financial Sector Threats Report 2025 (https://www.knowbe4.com/press/knowbe4-report-reveals-global-financial-sector-faces-unprecedented-cyber-threat-surge)
Pretexting share of social eng	50%+	Verizon DBIR 2025 (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/)
Breaches involving phishing/social eng	42%	SentinelOne / Industry Reports (https://www.sentinelone.com/cybersecurity-101/cybersecurity/cyber-security-statistics/)
Attacks involving social eng (Q1 2024)	90%	Avast Q1 2024 Threat Report (https://www.cobalt.io/blog/top-cybersecurity-statistics-2025)

\$129K Per BEC Complaint

FBI IC3 recorded \$2.77 billion in BEC losses from 21,442 complaints in 2024 — that's approximately \$129K per complaint. BEC requires no malware, no exploits, just convincing impersonation. (FBI IC3 2024)

Why BEC Is So Effective

BEC requires no malware, no exploits, and no technical sophistication — just convincing impersonation. An attacker spoofs or compromises a CEO's email, sends a wire transfer request to the finance team, and the money moves. The average BEC loss per incident is \$160,000+ (Arctic Wolf 2025), and the largest single BEC attacks have cost organisations tens of millions. BEC volume surged 54% in H1 2025 compared to 2023 (Abnormal Security), driven by AI-generated content that makes fraudulent emails virtually indistinguishable from legitimate ones.

The FBI's \$2.77 billion in reported BEC losses almost certainly understates the true figure — many organisations don't report losses, and smaller BEC attempts may go undetected entirely. BEC now accounts for 58% of financially motivated phishing breaches (Verizon DBIR 2025) and 27% of all investigated incidents (Arctic Wolf 2025). Pretexting — where attackers build a fabricated scenario to manipulate the victim — accounts for over 50% of social engineering incidents (Verizon DBIR 2025).

Social Engineering: The Foundation of All Phishing

98% of cyberattacks involve social engineering (Sprinto). This statistic reframes the entire cybersecurity landscape: the primary vulnerability is not in software, hardware, or network architecture — it's in human decision-making. 90% of Q1 2024 attacks involved social engineering (Avast). 42% of organisations cite phishing and social engineering as their top cyber risk (WEF 2025). 68% of cyberattacks originate from email (KnowBe4 2025).

Highest-Cost Phishing Types

- BEC — \$4.67M avg attack cost (IBM)
- Spear phishing — 54% click rate (HBR)
- Insider phishing — \$805K per incident (Ponemon)

Fastest-Growing Vectors

- Vishing — +442% surge (CrowdStrike)
- QR phishing — +400% increase (Hoxhunt)
- Smishing — +40% YoY (Keepnet)

BEC Attack Variations

BEC attacks come in several distinct variations, each targeting different organisational vulnerabilities:

CEO Fraud

Attacker impersonates the CEO or C-suite executive, requesting urgent wire transfers to finance staff. The urgency and authority of the request bypasses normal verification procedures.

Vendor Impersonation

Attacker impersonates a legitimate vendor, sending fake invoices or requesting payment detail changes. Often follows actual vendor email compromise, giving the attacker access to real invoice formats and

communication styles.

Payroll Diversion

Attacker impersonates an employee and contacts HR/payroll to change direct deposit information. The next payroll cycle routes the employee's salary to the attacker's account.

Attorney Impersonation

Attacker poses as a lawyer or legal representative, citing confidential matters that require immediate payment. The legal context creates urgency and discourages the target from seeking verification.

Data Theft

Rather than requesting money, the attacker requests sensitive data — employee W-2s, customer databases, intellectual property. These requests often come disguised as legitimate internal data requests.

The common thread across all BEC variants is social engineering — exploiting trust, authority, and urgency to bypass security controls. Effective BEC prevention requires out-of-band verification procedures (confirming wire transfer requests via phone call to a known number, not the number in the email), payment change protocols with mandatory dual-approval, and AI-based email analysis that detects subtle anomalies in communication patterns.



Vishing & Smishing Trends

VISHING ATTACKS

+442% ^ H1→H2 2024

Vishing (voice phishing) surged 442% from H1 to H2 2024 (CrowdStrike 2025), making it the fastest-growing phishing vector. AI voice cloning enables attackers to replicate a person's voice from just 3 seconds of audio (McAfee 2024). The largest vishing-related scam was a \$25 million deepfake CFO video call (CrowdStrike 2024).

Smishing (SMS phishing) accounts for 35% of all phishing attacks (SentinelOne 2026) and surged 40% year-over-year (Keepnet 2025). 19% of breaches now originate from smishing or vishing combined (Verizon DBIR 2025). 83% of phishing websites specifically target mobile devices (Zimmerium 2024), reflecting the shift to mobile-first attack strategies.

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Vishing attack surge (H1→H2 2024)	442%	CrowdStrike 2025 Global Threat Report (https://www.crowdstrike.com/en-us/press-releases/crowdstrike-releases-2025-global-threat-report/).
Voice phishing increase YoY	442%	CrowdStrike 2025 Global Threat Report (https://www.crowdstrike.com/en-us/press-releases/crowdstrike-releases-2025-global-threat-report/).
Smishing/vishing in breaches	19%	Verizon DBIR 2025 (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/).
Smishing share of phishing attacks	35%	SentinelOne / Industry Reports (https://www.sentinelone.com/cybersecurity-101/cybersecurity/cyber-security-statistics/).
Smishing surge YoY	40%	APWG / Keepnet (https://keepnetlabs.com/blog/smishing-statistics-the-latest-trends-and-numbers-in-sms-phishing).

The Multi-Channel Phishing Storm

Email phishing (3.4B/day), vishing (+442%, CrowdStrike 2025), and smishing (+40%, Keepnet 2025) are converging into a coordinated multi-channel threat. 35% of phishing now uses SMS/messaging apps (SentinelOne 2026), and 19% of breaches originate from smishing or vishing (Verizon DBIR 2025). Traditional email-only defenses miss two-thirds of the attack surface.

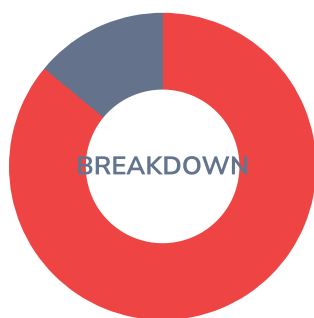
The AI Voice Cloning Threat

The 442% vishing surge is directly linked to advances in AI voice cloning. McAfee reports that just 3 seconds of audio — from a YouTube video, conference recording, or voicemail greeting — is enough to create a convincing voice clone (McAfee 2024). Attackers use these clones to impersonate executives, requesting urgent wire transfers or sensitive information via phone calls. The \$25 million deepfake CFO scam (CrowdStrike 2024) used video deepfake technology on a live call — the finance employee believed they were speaking with their actual CFO.

Smishing exploits a different vulnerability: trust in SMS. Text messages carry more implicit authority than email — a bank alert, delivery notification, or government notice via SMS triggers faster responses with less scrutiny. 83% of phishing websites are now designed for mobile screens (Zimmerium 2024), optimised for the smaller display where URL inspection is harder. QR code phishing (+400%, Hoxhunt 2025) bridges physical and digital attack surfaces, appearing in printed materials, emails, and even fake parking meters.



Phishing Targets by Industry



- Links (URL-based) **86% (86%)**
- Attachments **14% (14%)**

Phishing is the initial breach vector in 16% of all data breaches (IBM 2025) and appears in 36% of breaches overall (Verizon DBIR 2025). 33% of cloud-related security incidents originate from phishing (IBM X-Force 2025). The phishing insider incident cost averages \$804,997 (Ponemon 2025), and 55% of insider incidents are triggered by phishing.

Countries Targeted

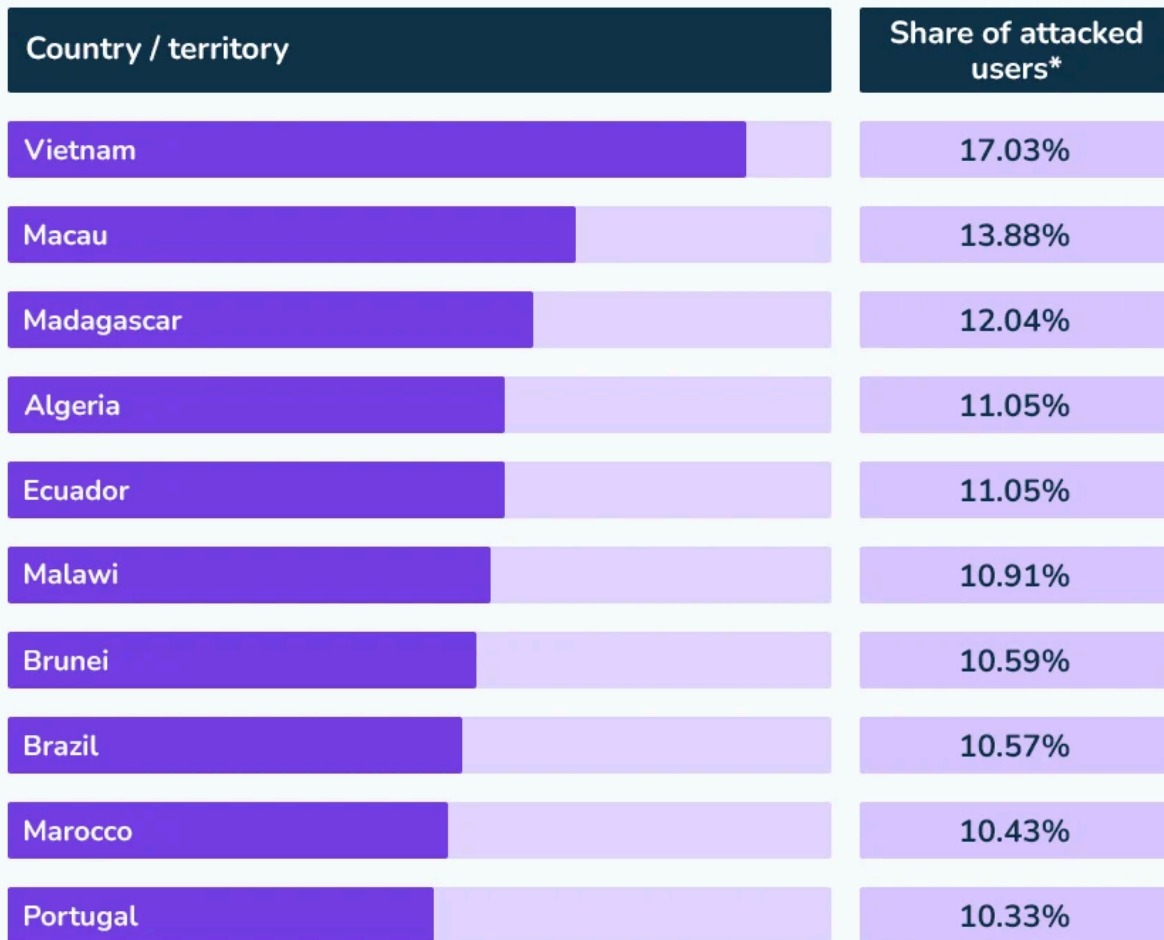
Country	Number of Emails	Percentage
Netherlands	68,908,098	17.6777%
Russia	53,211,482	13.6509%
Moldova	27,192,790	6.9760%
USA	24,135,668	6.1918%
Thailand	21,935,110	5.6272%
China	14,574,632	3.7390%
Germany	13,486,816	3.4599%
Great Britain	11,394,190	2.9231%
India	11,311,772	2.9019%
Vietnam	11,231,432	2.8813%
Other Countries	2,157,990	0.5536%



Industry targeting patterns show that phishing is not evenly distributed. Financial services face the highest attack frequency — 300x more attacks than other industries (KnowBe4 2025) — because the direct path from credential theft to monetary gain is shortest. Healthcare is heavily targeted due to the value of medical records and the urgency culture that makes staff susceptible to "urgent action required" messages. Education faces the highest click rates due to a transient population (students, adjunct faculty) with varying security awareness levels.

Cloud-related phishing (33% of cloud incidents, IBM X-Force 2025) targets organisations migrating to cloud platforms, exploiting confusion about new login portals and credential management. Phishing-triggered insider incidents cost \$804,997 on average (Ponemon 2025), and 55% of all insider incidents begin with a phishing email — making phishing the primary gateway to insider threats as well.

Top 10 Countries Kaspersky Users Are Experiencing Attacks



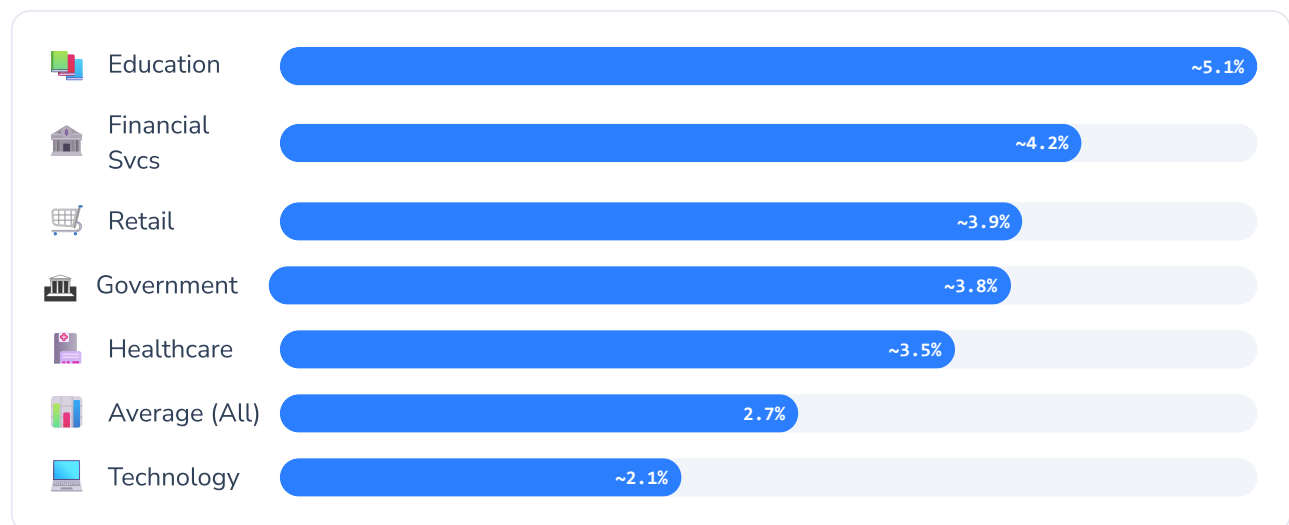
FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
All security incidents that are phishing	80%	CSO Online (https://www.csoonline.com/article/519878/phishing-statistics.html).
Phishing as initial breach vector	16%	IBM Cost of a Data Breach Report 2025 (https://www.ibm.com/reports/data-breach).
Cloud incidents from phishing	33%	IBM X-Force (https://www.ibm.com/reports/threat-intelligence).
Phishing insider incident cost	\$804,997	Ponemon Insider Threat Report 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Insider incidents triggered by phishing	55%	Ponemon Insider Threat Report 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/)

Industry Click Rate Comparison

Phishing click rates vary significantly by industry, driven by workforce composition, security culture, and attack sophistication. Education consistently shows the highest baseline click rates (~5.1%) due to transient student populations, adjunct faculty with limited security training, and open academic environments that prioritise accessibility over restriction. Financial services faces the highest attack frequency but has lower click rates (~4.2%) thanks to regulatory-driven security awareness programs.

Technology companies show the lowest baseline click rates (~2.1%), reflecting a workforce more attuned to cybersecurity risks and more likely to recognise phishing indicators. Healthcare (~3.5%) and government (~3.8%) fall in the middle — both face sophisticated targeting but have varying levels of security awareness maturity. Retail (~3.9%) is increasingly targeted as e-commerce grows, with attackers impersonating delivery services and payment platforms.



Phishing in Supply Chain Attacks

Phishing is increasingly used as the initial vector for supply chain compromises. Attackers target employees at third-party vendors, MSPs, or software suppliers — organisations that often have privileged access to their clients' systems. A single compromised vendor account can cascade to dozens or hundreds of downstream organisations. IBM reports that third-party breaches doubled year-over-year to 30% of all incidents, with supply chain compromises costing \$4.91 million on average.

The supply chain phishing attack surface is expanding as organisations adopt more SaaS tools, each with its own authentication system. Every vendor login page is a potential phishing target. Organisations should require phishing-resistant MFA for all vendor access, conduct security

assessments of critical suppliers' email security posture, and implement conditional access policies that restrict vendor access by IP, device, and geography.

Phishing Risk Estimator

Estimate your annual phishing exposure based on industry and employee count.

Industry

Financial Services

Employees: 1,000

Security awareness training

DAILY PHISHING EMAILS

~8,100

ESTIMATED CLICKS/MONTH

~10,206

EST. ANNUAL PHISHING COST

~\$24.8M

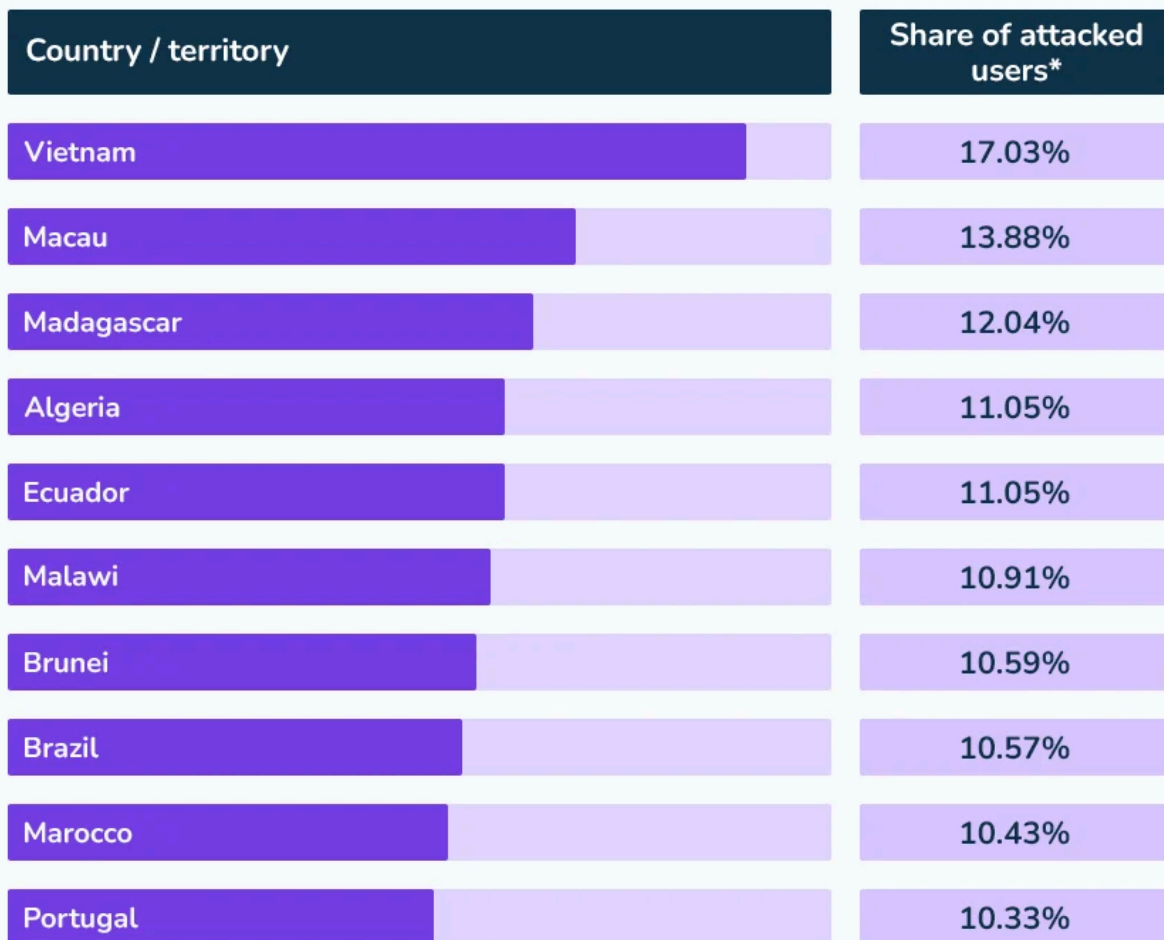
Estimates based on 3.4B daily phishing emails, industry click rates, and \$17,700/min phishing cost data.



Phishing Targets by Country

The United States is the primary target for phishing attacks, with the FBI IC3 receiving 193,407 phishing complaints in 2024. US BEC losses alone totalled \$2.77 billion. Cryptocurrency-related phishing accounted for an additional \$28.5 million in FBI-reported losses. The Netherlands (17.7%), Russia (13.7%), and other countries show distinct targeting patterns based on financial sector presence and digital infrastructure maturity.

Top 10 Countries Kaspersky Users Are Experiencing Attacks



FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
FBI phishing complaints (US, 2024)	193,407	FBI Internet Crime Report 2024 (https://www.ic3.gov/AnnualReport/Reports/2024_IC3Report.pdf)
FBI BEC losses (US, 2024)	\$2.77B	FBI Internet Crime Report 2024 (https://www.ic3.gov/AnnualReport/Reports/2024_IC3Report.pdf)
FBI crypto phishing losses (US)	\$28.5M	FBI Internet Crime Report 2024 (https://www.ic3.gov/AnnualReport/Reports/2024_IC3Report.pdf)

Regional Phishing Patterns

Phishing targeting varies significantly by region. The Netherlands receives 17.7% of global phishing emails — disproportionate to its population — due to its role as a major European financial and logistics hub. Russia (13.7%) and other Eastern European countries see high volumes both as targets and as source countries. The APAC region faces distinct phishing campaigns tailored to local languages and banking systems, with mobile-first attacks dominating in markets where smartphone penetration exceeds desktop usage.

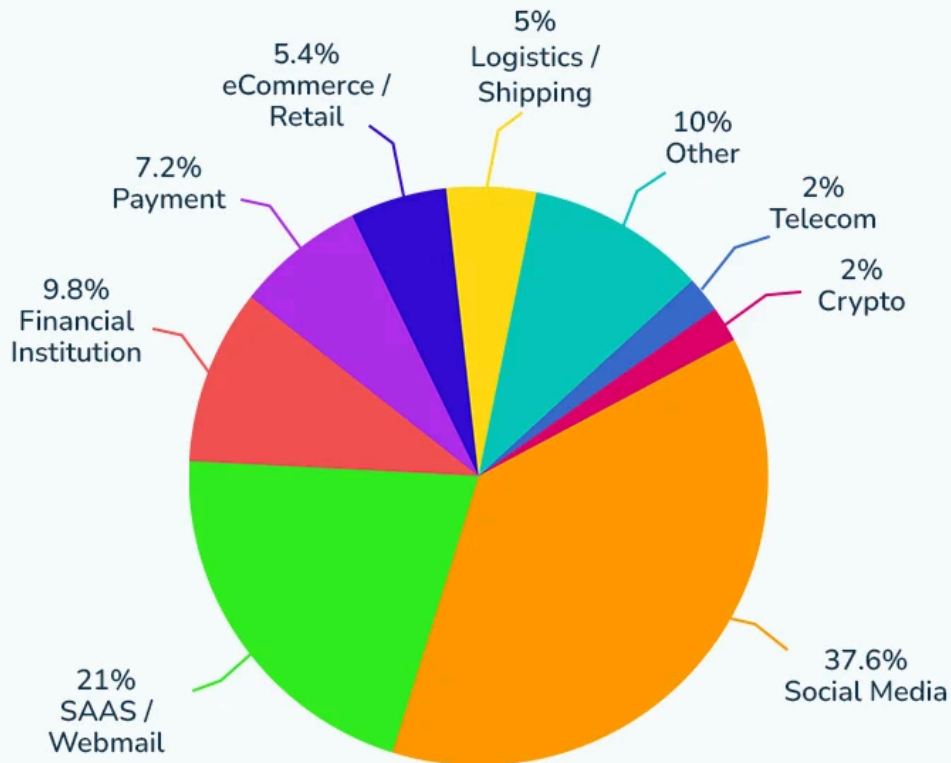
Cryptocurrency-related phishing is a growing subset, with the FBI reporting \$28.5 million in crypto phishing losses in 2024 (FBI IC3). These attacks mimic legitimate cryptocurrency exchanges, wallets, and DeFi platforms, exploiting the irreversible nature of cryptocurrency transactions. Once funds are transferred to an attacker's wallet, recovery is virtually impossible.

Top Phishing Brands and Impersonation Targets

Attackers impersonate the brands people trust most. Microsoft, Google, Apple, Amazon, and major banks are consistently the most impersonated brands in phishing campaigns. Microsoft 365 phishing is particularly prevalent because compromising a Microsoft account gives attackers access to email, OneDrive, SharePoint, and Teams — the entire digital workplace. Google Workspace phishing follows the same logic.

Delivery service impersonation (DHL, FedEx, Royal Mail) has surged alongside the growth of e-commerce. "Your package is being held" and "delivery attempted" messages generate urgency without requiring any prior relationship with the target. Government impersonation (HMRC, IRS, tax agencies) spikes during tax seasons. Banking phishing ("unusual activity detected on your account") remains one of the highest-conversion phishing categories because it triggers immediate fear of financial loss.

Phishing: Most Targeted Industries (Q1 2024)



STATIONX



Phishing Delivery Methods

86%

URL/Link-Based
of malicious spam

+400%

QR Code Phishing
increase 2023-2025

83%

Mobile-Targeted
of phishing sites

86% of malicious spam now uses embedded links rather than attachments (VIPRE 2024), reflecting a strategic shift toward credential-harvesting landing pages that evade attachment-scanning defenses. QR code phishing (quishing) increased 400% between 2023 and 2025 (Hoxhunt), exploiting the trust users place in QR codes and the difficulty of previewing URLs on mobile devices.

60% of phishing incidents are identity-based (Cisco 2025), targeting credentials rather than deploying malware. The average phishing site lasts just 12 hours before takedown (BlackBerry 2025), but that's enough time — with a 21-second click time and 92 million daily clicks, most damage occurs within the first hour. 83% of phishing websites specifically target mobile users (Zimperium 2024).

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Malspam using links vs attachments	86%	VIPRE Security Group Q2 2024 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).
QR code phishing increase	400%	Hoxhunt Phishing Trends Report (https://hoxhunt.com/guide/phishing-trends-report).
Identity-based phishing incidents	60%	Cisco Cybersecurity Readiness Index 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).
Average phishing site lifespan	12 hours	BlackBerry Global Threat Intelligence 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).
Mobile-targeted phishing sites	83%	Zimperium Mobile Threat Report 2024 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/cybercrime-statistics/).

The QR Code Phishing Explosion

QR code phishing (quishing) deserves special attention. The 400% increase (Hoxhunt 2025) reflects a fundamental gap in email security: most email gateways scan URLs and attachments but cannot interpret QR codes embedded as images. Attackers exploit this by embedding malicious QR codes in otherwise clean emails, bypassing traditional link-scanning defenses entirely. When users scan the QR code with their phone, they're redirected to a credential-harvesting site outside the corporate network's security controls.

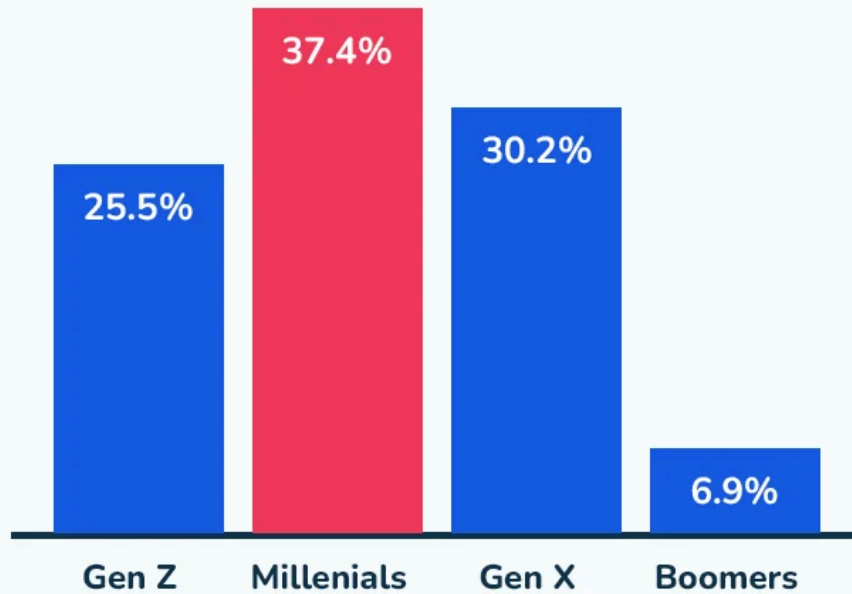
Identity-based phishing (60% of incidents, Cisco 2025) represents the convergence of phishing with credential theft. Rather than deploying malware, modern phishing focuses on harvesting usernames and passwords through convincing login page replicas. With stolen credentials, attackers gain legitimate access that bypasses most perimeter defenses — no exploit needed, no malware to detect, just a valid login from a "trusted" user.

Adversary-in-the-Middle (AitM) Phishing

A sophisticated evolution of credential phishing is the Adversary-in-the-Middle (AitM) attack, where the phishing site acts as a real-time proxy between the victim and the legitimate login page. The victim enters their credentials and even their MFA token — both are captured and immediately relayed to the real site. The attacker gains a fully authenticated session, bypassing standard MFA. AitM phishing kits are now available as commodity tools on dark web marketplaces, making this advanced technique accessible to low-skill attackers.

Only phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2/passkeys, hardware security keys) defeats AitM attacks, because these methods verify the actual domain of the login page cryptographically. If the domain doesn't match, the authentication fails — even if the user is fooled. This is why the industry is rapidly moving toward passwordless authentication using passkeys, which eliminate the credential-harvesting attack surface entirely.

Phishing: Top Targets by Age



STATIONX



Cost of Phishing Attacks

\$25B

Annual Global Phishing Losses

Source: SentinelOne 2026

Global phishing losses total \$25 billion annually (SentinelOne 2026). \$17,700 is lost to phishing every minute (CSO Online). The average BEC attack costs \$4.67 million (IBM 2025), while the average BEC loss per incident is \$160,000+ (Arctic Wolf 2025). Phishing-related insider incidents average \$804,997 each (Ponemon 2025).

71% of organisations expect a business-disrupting cyber incident in the next 12-24 months (Cisco 2025), with phishing as the most likely entry point. The cost compounds across the attack chain: a successful phishing click leads to credential theft, lateral movement, data exfiltration, or ransomware deployment — each adding to the total breach cost.

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Annual global phishing losses	\$25B	CDNetworks / SentinelOne (https://www.sentinelone.com/cybersecurity-101/cybersecurity/cyber-security-statistics/).
Lost to phishing every minute	\$17,700	CSO Online (https://www.csoonline.com/article/519878/phishing-statistics.html).
Average BEC attack cost	\$4.67M	IBM / HoxHunt (https://www.vikingcloud.com/blog/cybersecurity-statistics).
Average BEC loss per incident	\$160,000+	Arctic Wolf Threat Report 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).
Phishing insider incident cost	\$804,997	Ponemon Insider Threat Report 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).
Orgs expecting disruptive incident	71%	Cisco Cybersecurity Readiness Index 2025 (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/).

The Compounding Cost Chain

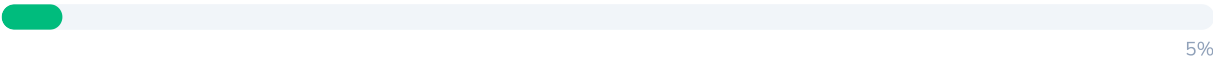
Phishing rarely ends at the initial click. The cost compounds through a chain of consequences: credential theft leads to account compromise, which enables lateral movement, data exfiltration, and often ransomware deployment. IBM reports that breaches originating from phishing take an average of 241 days to identify and contain — one of the longest lifecycles of any attack vector. Each additional day of undetected access increases the total breach cost.

For organisations, the true cost of phishing includes direct financial losses, incident response costs, regulatory fines, legal expenses, reputational damage, customer churn, and business disruption. The \$25 billion annual figure captures only the measurable direct losses. Including indirect costs — productivity loss from security lockdowns, executive time spent on breach response, increased insurance premiums — the total impact is substantially higher.

The Phishing Attack Chain

Phishing email (3.4B/day) → Click (21 sec) → Credential harvest → Account compromise → Lateral movement → Data exfiltration or ransomware → Average breach cost: \$4.44M (IBM 2025)





Security awareness training reduces phishing susceptibility to under 5%, down from an industry baseline of approximately 33% (KnowBe4 2025). That's an 85%+ reduction in click-through rates. The median time to report phishing is 28 minutes (Verizon DBIR 2025), but trained users report faster. The gap between click time (21 seconds) and report time (28 minutes) represents the critical window for attacker exploitation.

Phishing sites last an average of 12 hours before takedown (BlackBerry 2025), underscoring the importance of pre-click defenses (email filtering, URL sandboxing) over post-click remediation. Multi-factor authentication — particularly phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2/passkeys) — provides the strongest defense against credential-harvesting phishing, even when users click.

FINDING	VALUE	SOURCE
Susceptibility after training	<5%	KnowBe4 Financial Sector Threats Report 2025 . (https://www.knowbe4.com/press/knowbe4-report-reveals-global-financial-sector-faces-unprecedented-cyber-threat-surge)
Median time to report phishing	28 minutes	Verizon DBIR 2025 . (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/)
Median time to click (21 sec)	21 seconds	Verizon DBIR 2025 . (https://www.verizon.com/business/resources/reports/dbir/)
Phishing site lifespan (12 hrs)	12 hours	BlackBerry Global Threat Intelligence 2025 . (https://www.brightdefense.com/resources/phishing-statistics/)

Training Cuts Susceptibility by 85%+

KnowBe4 reports phishing susceptibility drops to under 5% after comprehensive security awareness training — down from an industry average baseline of ~33% before training. The median time to report phishing (28 minutes) also improves dramatically with trained users. The ROI case for training is now quantifiable: fewer clicks means fewer breaches.

Layered Phishing Defense Strategy

Effective phishing defense requires a layered approach. No single control stops all phishing — the 2.7% click rate persists even with email filtering because attackers constantly evolve their techniques. The most effective defence stack combines: (1) email gateway filtering with AI-based

detection, (2) URL sandboxing and real-time link analysis, (3) regular security awareness training to reduce susceptibility below 5%, (4) phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2/passkeys) to prevent credential exploitation even after a click, and (5) endpoint detection to catch post-compromise lateral movement.

The economics favour defense: security awareness training costs a fraction of a single phishing breach. Reducing click rates from the industry baseline (~33%) to under 5% with comprehensive training eliminates 85%+ of the risk surface. Adding phishing-resistant MFA closes most of the remaining gap — even if a user clicks and enters credentials on a fake site, the attacker cannot use those credentials without the physical security key or passkey.

The Defense ROI

Security awareness training: ~\$25/employee/year. Phishing-resistant MFA: ~\$5/user/month. Average phishing breach cost: \$4.44M. The math is straightforward — investing \$100K in training and MFA for a 1,000-person organisation eliminates 90%+ of the risk from phishing attacks costing millions.

Incident Response for Phishing

When phishing succeeds — and it will, despite the best defenses — the speed of response determines the damage. Organisations with a documented incident response plan specifically for phishing events contain breaches faster and at lower cost. The response playbook should include: immediate credential reset for compromised accounts, session token revocation, email quarantine of additional messages from the same campaign, forensic analysis of what data was accessed, and notification to affected parties.

Automated response orchestration (SOAR platforms) can execute the first four steps within minutes of a confirmed phishing compromise, dramatically reducing the attacker's operational window. When the median time from click to report is 28 minutes, automated response can close the gap that manual processes cannot. Organisations that combine user training, phishing-resistant MFA, email filtering, and automated incident response achieve the strongest defensive posture against phishing attacks.

Phishing Simulation Programs

The most effective security awareness programs include regular phishing simulations — controlled phishing campaigns that test employee awareness without real risk. These simulations measure click rates, report rates, and susceptibility trends over time. KnowBe4's data showing susceptibility dropping to under 5% after training comes from organisations running monthly simulation campaigns combined with just-in-time training for employees who click.

Simulation programs work best when they evolve: initial tests use obvious phishing indicators, progressively introducing more sophisticated techniques including AI-generated content, impersonation of internal employees, and multi-channel attacks (email followed by a "verification" phone call). Organisations that run quarterly simulations see 50-60% improvement in the first year. Those running monthly simulations with immediate feedback see 70-80%+ improvement within 6 months.

Biggest Phishing Attacks & Notable Campaigns

The biggest phishing attacks in recent years demonstrate how the threat has evolved from mass-blast emails to sophisticated, multi-channel campaigns leveraging AI, deepfakes, and social engineering at scale. Here are the most significant:

\$25M Deepfake CFO Scam (2024)

Attackers used AI-generated deepfake video to impersonate a company's CFO on a video call, convincing a finance employee to transfer \$25 million. The attack combined vishing, deepfake technology, and social engineering in a single coordinated campaign. Multiple participants on the call were deepfaked — only the victim was real (CrowdStrike 2024).

\$1.5B Lazarus Group ByBit Heist (2025)

North Korea's Lazarus Group executed a \$1.5 billion cryptocurrency heist against ByBit in 2025, believed to have originated from a spear phishing attack targeting an exchange employee. The attack demonstrates how a single phishing email can cascade into the largest cryptocurrency theft in history.

442% Vishing Surge (H2 2024)

CrowdStrike documented a 442% surge in voice phishing between H1 and H2 2024, driven by AI voice cloning tools that can replicate any voice from 3 seconds of audio. This was not a single campaign but an industry-wide shift — attackers increasingly use phone calls to bypass email security filters entirely, targeting IT help desks, finance teams, and executives.

QR Code Phishing Explosion (+400%)

QR code phishing (quishing) increased 400% between 2023 and 2025 (Hoxhunt). Attackers embed malicious QR codes in emails, printed flyers, and even over legitimate QR codes on parking meters and restaurant menus. Users scan with mobile devices, bypassing desktop email security controls and landing on credential-harvesting sites designed for mobile screens.

AI-Generated BEC Surge (2024-2025)

40% of BEC emails in Q2 2024 were identified as AI-generated (VIPRE). BEC volume surged 54% in H1 2025 vs 2023 (Abnormal Security). AI-generated BEC attacks are nearly impossible to distinguish from legitimate executive communications, with personalised writing styles, contextually relevant content, and grammatically perfect prose across multiple languages.

Phishing vs Other Attack Vectors

Phishing is not just one attack vector among many — it's the gateway to most others. Ransomware, credential theft, business email compromise, insider threats, and supply chain attacks frequently begin with a phishing email. IBM reports phishing as the initial vector in 16% of breaches, but its downstream impact is far broader: stolen credentials from phishing enable 53% of all breaches (Verizon DBIR 2025), and phishing triggers 55% of insider incidents (Ponemon 2025).

Phishing: The Breach Gateway

- 36% of breaches involve phishing (Verizon)
- 16% initial breach vector (IBM)
- 55% of insider incidents start with phishing
- 68% of cyberattacks originate from email

What Phishing Enables

- Credential theft → 53% of breaches
- Ransomware deployment
- BEC wire fraud (\$2.77B/year)
- Supply chain compromise

The Evolution of Phishing Tactics

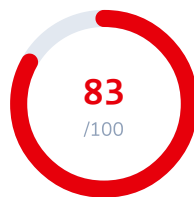
Phishing has evolved through distinct generations. First-generation attacks (early 2000s) were mass-blast emails with obvious indicators — foreign princes, lottery winnings, Nigerian bank transfers. Second-generation attacks (2010s) introduced brand impersonation, landing page cloning, and industry-targeted campaigns. Third-generation attacks (2020s) leverage AI content

generation, multi-channel delivery, AitM credential proxying, and deepfake technology. Each generation made the previous generation's defenses insufficient.

The current fourth-generation threat combines all previous capabilities with autonomous AI agents that can conduct entire social engineering campaigns end-to-end: researching targets, crafting personalised messages, adapting in real-time to responses, and even conducting follow-up calls using voice clones. While this capability is still emerging, the building blocks are all commercially available. Security planning for 2026-2028 must account for this trajectory.

Mobile Phishing Statistics

MOBILE-TARGETED PHISHING SITES



83% of phishing websites specifically target mobile devices (Zimperium 2024). Smishing accounts for 35% of all phishing attacks (SentinelOne 2026), and the smishing surge hit 40% year-over-year growth (Keepnet 2025). Mobile phishing is harder to detect: smaller screens hide URL previews, and SMS messages carry more implicit trust than email. QR code phishing (+400%, Hoxhunt 2025) further exploits mobile-first behaviour.

The mobile attack surface extends beyond SMS. Messaging apps (WhatsApp, Telegram, Slack), social media DMs, and even calendar invites are used as phishing delivery channels. Mobile banking trojans have surged (Kaspersky 2024), often delivered through smishing links. Organisations relying solely on desktop email security miss a significant portion of the phishing threat landscape.

Why Mobile Phishing Works

Mobile devices create a perfect environment for phishing success. Smaller screens hide URL bars and make it harder to inspect links before clicking. Push notifications create urgency — a text message reading "Your account has been compromised, verify now" triggers immediate action on a device designed for instant response. Mobile browsers often lack the security extensions available on desktop. And personal devices typically operate outside corporate security controls, meaning no email gateway, no URL sandboxing, and no endpoint detection.

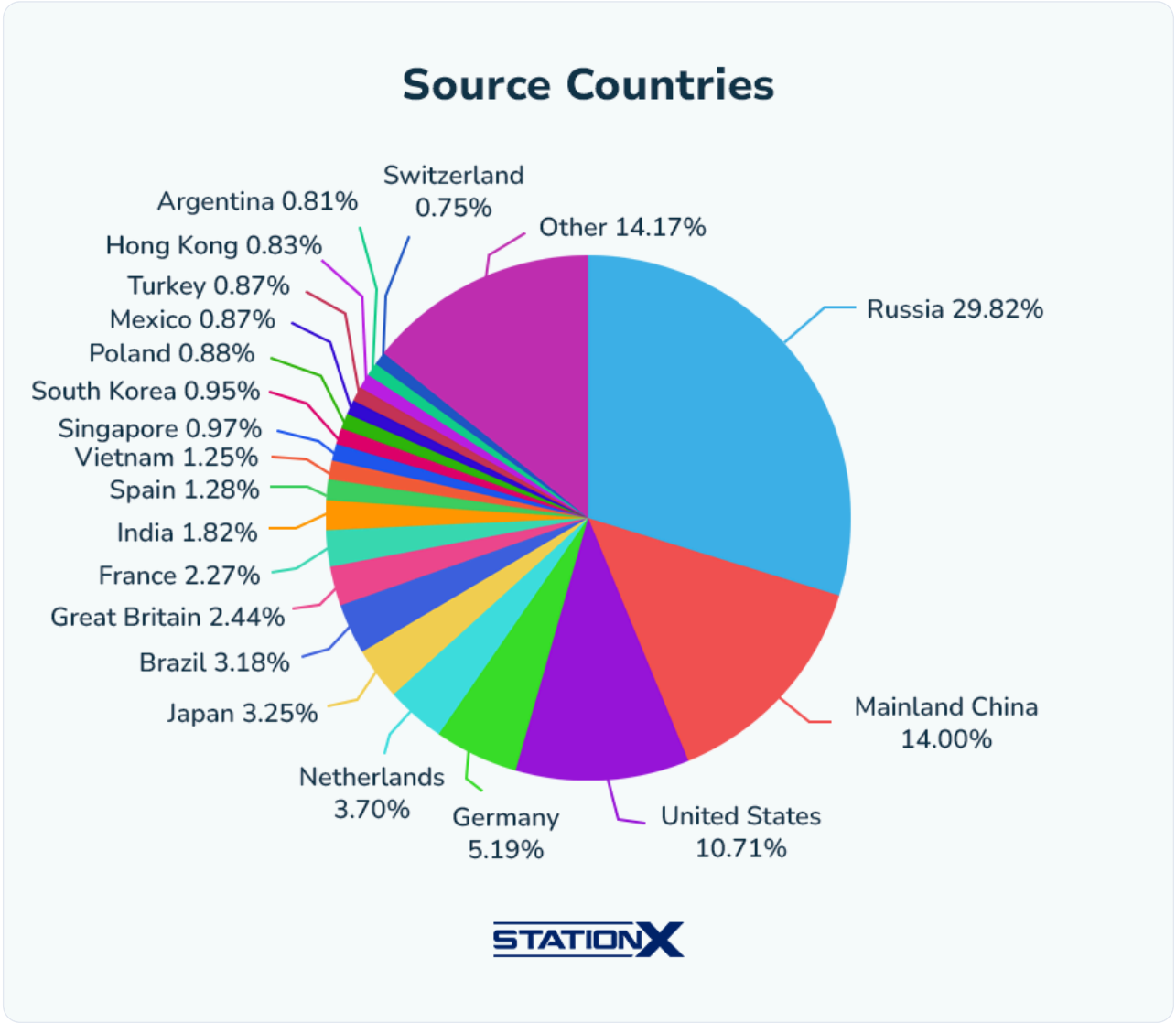
The convergence of work and personal communication on mobile devices compounds the risk. Employees accessing corporate email, Slack, Teams, and other work tools on the same device where they receive personal SMS and social media messages means a smishing attack can reach a

corporate user through a completely unmonitored channel. QR code phishing bridges physical spaces — attackers have placed malicious QR codes over legitimate ones on parking meters, restaurant menus, and even corporate visitor badges.

Mobile Phishing Defense Gaps

Most enterprise security stacks were designed for desktop environments. Email security gateways filter corporate email, but they cannot scan personal SMS messages, WhatsApp conversations, or social media DMs on employee phones. This creates a fundamental visibility gap: the device that has the most access to corporate systems (mobile, with SSO apps, email, Slack, VPN) is also the device with the least security monitoring.

Mobile threat defense (MTD) solutions and mobile device management (MDM) platforms can close some of these gaps by scanning URLs before they open in mobile browsers, detecting phishing apps, and enforcing security policies on managed devices. However, adoption remains low — many organisations still treat mobile security as an afterthought. Given that 83% of phishing sites target mobile users (Zimperium 2024) and 35% of phishing uses SMS/messaging (SentinelOne 2026), this gap represents one of the largest unaddressed phishing risk surfaces.





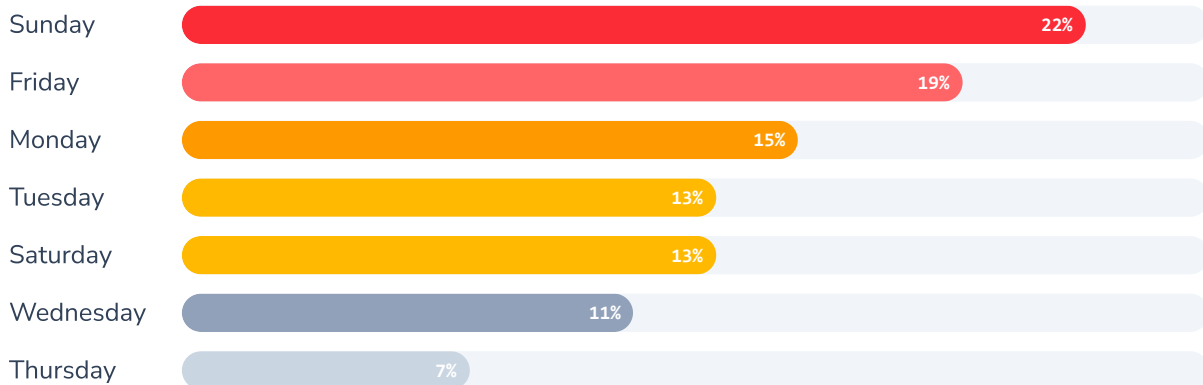
How Often Do Phishing Attacks Happen?

Phishing emails peak on Sundays (22% of weekly volume) and Fridays (19%), with Thursday being the lowest day at 7% (StationX analysis). This pattern suggests attackers target weekends and end-of-week fatigue, when recipients are less likely to scrutinise emails carefully. Monday (15%) and Tuesday (13%) see moderate volumes, while Wednesday (11%) and Saturday (13%) fall in between.

These timing patterns have direct implications for security operations. SOC teams should increase email monitoring coverage on Sundays and Fridays, when phishing volume peaks. Automated email security rules can apply stricter filtering during high-risk periods. Security awareness training should specifically address weekend and end-of-week vigilance, since attackers deliberately time campaigns to exploit periods of reduced attention.

Time-of-day patterns also matter. Phishing emails timed to arrive early Monday morning — when employees face hundreds of accumulated weekend emails — achieve higher click rates than those sent mid-afternoon on a Tuesday. Attackers study recipient behaviour, timing delivery for maximum impact. Enterprise email security that queues and rescans early-morning email batches can catch threats that real-time filters miss under volume pressure.

Phishing Volume by Day of Week



Seasonal Phishing Patterns

Beyond day-of-week patterns, phishing follows seasonal trends tied to cultural and business events. Tax season (January-April in the US, January-January in the UK) drives government impersonation phishing — HMRC, IRS, and tax authority phishing spikes 3-4x during filing periods. Holiday shopping seasons (November-December) see surges in delivery service and retail brand impersonation. Back-to-school periods drive education-sector targeting. Year-end financial reporting triggers BEC attacks targeting finance teams under deadline pressure.

Major news events create phishing opportunities. Natural disasters trigger fake charity phishing. Product launches (new iPhone, major software releases) generate fake pre-order and update phishing. Health crises create fake government alert phishing. Geopolitical events create fake news

and sanction-related phishing targeting businesses. Attackers monitor the news cycle and launch themed campaigns within hours of breaking events, exploiting heightened emotion and reduced critical thinking.

Phishing Statistics Year-Over-Year

Comparing phishing statistics across years reveals acceleration, not stability. APWG data shows the trajectory: approximately 1 million attacks in 2020, 1.3 million in 2021, 2.35 million in 2022, 3.2 million in 2023, and 3.8 million in 2025. The compounding growth rate of 30-40% annually shows no sign of slowing, particularly as AI tools further reduce the cost and effort of launching campaigns.

BEC losses have followed a similar trajectory: FBI IC3 reported \$1.8 billion in 2020, \$2.4 billion in 2021, \$2.7 billion in 2022, \$2.9 billion in 2023, and \$2.77 billion in 2024. While the 2024 figure shows a slight decline from 2023, the overall trend remains upward, and the introduction of AI-generated BEC content in 2024-2025 suggests this may be a brief pause before renewed acceleration. The cost per BEC incident has increased even as total reported losses plateaued, indicating fewer but more sophisticated and higher-value attacks.

APWG Phishing Attacks by Year



Source: APWG Phishing Activity Trends Reports

FBI IC3 BEC Losses by Year



Source: FBI Internet Crime Reports 2020-2024



Phishing by the Numbers: Visual Summary

The following visual components summarise the key phishing statistics for 2026. Use these for presentations, security awareness sessions, and executive briefings.

3.4B

Daily Volume
phishing emails

82.6%

AI-Generated
of phishing emails

2.7%

Click Rate
average click-through

21 sec

Time to Click
median from delivery

\$25B

Annual Losses
global phishing losses

\$2.77B

BEC Losses
FBI-reported (2024)

\$17.7K

Per Minute
lost to phishing

\$4.67M

BEC Cost
avg attack cost (IBM)

+442%

Vishing Surge
H1→H2 2024

35%

Smishing Share
of phishing attacks

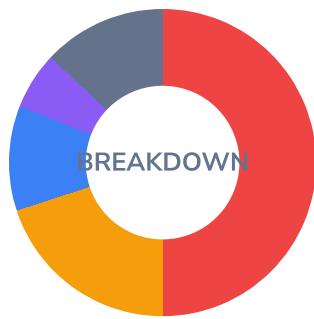
+400%

QR Phishing
increase 2023-2025

83%

Mobile Sites
target mobile devices

Attack Method Breakdown



Email Phishing (links)	86% (50%)
Smishing (SMS)	35% (20%)
Vishing (voice)	19% (11%)
QR Code Phishing	~10% (6%)
Other (social media, messaging)	~22% (13%)

Email remains the dominant phishing channel, but the multi-channel threat is growing rapidly. The percentages above represent share of overall phishing activity across channels — note that attacks often span multiple channels (e.g., an email that asks the recipient to call a phone number combines email phishing with vishing).

Phishing Defense Effectiveness



Defense effectiveness estimates are approximate, based on vendor data and industry benchmarks. Phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2/passkeys) provides the strongest single control because it cryptographically verifies the login domain, defeating even AitM attacks. The most effective defence combines multiple layers — no single control catches all phishing.

Building Your Anti-Phishing Stack

Based on the data in this article, here's the recommended anti-phishing defense stack ordered by impact:

Layer 1: Phishing-Resistant MFA (FIDO2/Passkeys)

Eliminates credential-harvesting effectiveness even when users click. Defeats AitM proxy attacks that bypass standard MFA. Deploy for all users, prioritising executives and finance staff.

Layer 2: Security Awareness Training + Monthly Simulations

Reduces click rates from ~33% baseline to under 5% (KnowBe4). Monthly simulations with just-in-time training achieve 70-80%+ improvement in 6 months. Include vishing and smishing simulations, not just email.

Layer 3: AI-Based Email Security Gateway

Catches AI-generated phishing that rule-based filters miss. Analyses sender behaviour, communication patterns, and content anomalies. Integrates with Microsoft 365 / Google Workspace.

Layer 4: URL Sandboxing & Real-Time Link Analysis

Detonates suspicious links in a sandbox before they reach users. Critical because 86% of malicious spam uses embedded links (VIPRE 2024). Time-of-click analysis catches delayed-activation phishing pages.

Layer 5: Automated Incident Response (SOAR)

Closes the 27.6-minute gap between first click and first report. Automatically resets compromised credentials, revokes sessions, quarantines campaign emails, and notifies affected users within minutes.

Layer 6: Mobile Threat Defense & MDM

Covers the 35% of phishing using SMS/messaging and 83% of phishing sites targeting mobile. Scans URLs on mobile devices, enforces security policies, and detects phishing apps.

Layer 7: Out-of-Band Verification Procedures

Confirms wire transfers, payment changes, and sensitive data requests via a separate communication channel (phone call to known number). Defeats BEC attacks regardless of email quality.

No single layer is sufficient. The data shows that even the best email filtering misses some phishing (82.6% AI-generated content challenges detection), that trained users still click occasionally (2.7% baseline with training), and that mobile and voice channels bypass email controls entirely. The strongest phishing defense is a combination of technical controls that prevent

credential exploitation (MFA), human controls that reduce click rates (training), and procedural controls that catch what both miss (verification protocols, automated response).



Key Takeaways for 2026

The phishing landscape in 2026 is defined by three converging trends: AI-powered content generation, multi-channel delivery (email + voice + SMS + QR), and identity-based attacks that bypass traditional security controls. Here's what the data tells us:

1. AI Has Permanently Changed Phishing Economics

82.6% of phishing emails are AI-generated. AI spear phishing matches human-expert click rates at 95% lower cost. The barrier to sophisticated phishing attacks has dropped to near zero, and the trend is accelerating.

2. Email-Only Defense Is No Longer Sufficient

Vishing surged 442%, smishing grew 40%, and QR code phishing increased 400%. 35% of phishing now uses SMS/messaging apps. Organisations defending only the email channel miss a growing share of attacks.

3. Training and Phishing-Resistant MFA Are the Highest-ROI Defenses

Training cuts susceptibility by 85%+ (from ~33% to <5%). Phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2/passkeys) prevents credential exploitation even when users click. Together, these two controls address 90%+ of phishing risk at a fraction of breach costs.

4. BEC Remains the Costliest Phishing Type

\$2.77B in FBI-reported BEC losses (2024), \$4.67M average BEC attack cost (IBM), and 54% volume surge in H1 2025. BEC requires no malware — just convincing impersonation, now supercharged by AI-generated content.

5. Speed Is the Attacker's Advantage

21 seconds to click, 28 minutes to report. That 27.6-minute gap is the attacker's window. Closing this gap through automated response, pre-click prevention, and real-time URL

About This Data

This article draws from **76 statistics** aggregated from 50+ authoritative sources including IBM Cost of a Data Breach, Verizon DBIR, CrowdStrike Global Threat Report, WEF Global Cybersecurity Outlook, FBI IC3, ISC2 Cybersecurity Workforce Study, Sophos, Gartner, Mandiant M-Trends, and Ponemon Institute reports.

Derived statistics (marked "Nathan House's Analysis") are computed by cross-referencing data from multiple sources — for example, comparing breach costs across industries using IBM data, or validating ransomware trends across Verizon, Sophos, and HIPAA Journal findings.

All statistics include inline source citations with links to primary sources. Data spans 2023-2026, with preference given to the most recent available figures. Last updated: **May 2026**.

How to Use This Data

Security professionals can use these phishing statistics to build business cases for email security investment, justify security awareness training budgets, and benchmark phishing resilience against industry averages. The derived insights highlight cost differentials and risk gaps that resonate with executive decision-makers.

For CISOs and security leaders: Use the \$25 billion annual phishing loss figure, \$4.67M average BEC cost, and 27.6-minute click-to-report gap to justify investment in phishing-resistant MFA, email security upgrades, and security awareness programs. The ROI data — training reducing susceptibility by 85%+ at ~\$25/employee/year — provides a clear cost-benefit argument.

For security awareness trainers: Use the day-of-week patterns, AI phishing statistics, and multi-channel threat data to design realistic simulation campaigns. Focus training on vishing and smishing, not just email — these are the fastest-growing vectors and the least defended.

For journalists and researchers: All statistics include inline source citations with links to primary sources. Derived statistics are clearly marked as "Nathan House's Analysis" with

computation methodology shown. Data spans 2023-2026, with preference given to the most recent available figures.

This page is updated monthly as new reports are published. Bookmark it and return for the latest phishing attack statistics. If you spot an outdated statistic or want to suggest a source, [contact us](https://www.stationx.net/contact/) (<https://www.stationx.net/contact/>).

About the Author



Nathan House, StationX

Nathan House is a cybersecurity expert with 30 years of hands-on experience. He holds OSCP, CISSP, and CEH certifications, has secured £71 billion in UK mobile banking transactions, and has worked with clients including Microsoft, Cisco, BP, Vodafone, and VISA. Named Cyber Security Educator of the Year 2020 and a UK Top 25 Security Influencer 2025, Nathan is a featured expert on CNN, Fox News, and NBC. He founded [StationX](https://www.stationx.net) (<https://www.stationx.net>), which has trained over 500,000 students in cybersecurity.

Primary Sources

Verizon DBIR 2025

Click rates, breach vectors, phishing in breaches, BEC data, social engineering trends

IBM Cost of a Data Breach 2025

BEC costs, phishing as breach vector, AI impact on detection and costs

FBI Internet Crime Report 2024

BEC losses, phishing complaints, crypto phishing, US-specific data

CrowdStrike Global Threat Report 2025

Vishing surge (442%), deepfake scams, AI-powered threats, voice cloning

APWG Phishing Trends Reports

Keepnet Labs / VIPRE Security

Quarterly and annual phishing attack volumes, year-over-year trends

AI-generated phishing rates (82.6%), BEC AI generation (40%), malspam analysis

HBR / Academic Research 2024

AI spear phishing click rates (54%), cost reduction analysis (95%+)

KnowBe4 / Ponemon / SentinelOne

Training effectiveness, insider phishing costs, global loss estimates, smishing data

? Frequently Asked Questions About Phishing

How many phishing emails are sent per day?

Approximately 3.4 billion phishing emails are sent every day worldwide. 82.6% of these are AI-generated (Keepnet/VIPRE 2025). That works out to roughly 39,000 phishing emails per second. The annual total tracked by APWG was 3.8 million distinct phishing attacks in 2025.

What percentage of cyber attacks are phishing?

Phishing appears in 36% of all data breaches (Verizon DBIR 2025) and is the initial attack vector in 16% of breaches (IBM 2025). 80% of all reported security incidents involve phishing in some form (CSO Online). When including all forms of social engineering (email, voice, SMS), 98% of cyberattacks involve social engineering (Sprinto).

How much does phishing cost businesses?

Global phishing losses total \$25 billion annually (SentinelOne 2026). The average BEC attack costs \$4.67 million (IBM 2025). The FBI reported \$2.77 billion in BEC losses alone in 2024 from 21,442 complaints — approximately \$129K per complaint. Phishing costs \$17,700 per minute globally (CSO Online), or approximately \$1.06 million per hour.

What is the phishing email click rate?

The average phishing email click rate is 2.7% (Verizon DBIR 2025). AI-generated spear phishing achieves a much higher 54% click rate (HBR 2024), matching skilled human attackers at 95% lower cost. The median time for a user to click a phishing link is just 21 seconds after receiving the email (Verizon DBIR 2025). With 3.4 billion daily phishing emails and a 2.7% click rate, that's approximately 92 million successful clicks per day.

How effective is phishing awareness training?

Comprehensive security awareness training reduces phishing susceptibility to under 5%, down from an industry baseline of approximately 33% — an 85%+ reduction (KnowBe4 2025).

Organisations running monthly phishing simulations with immediate feedback see 70-80%+ improvement within 6 months. Training also improves phishing reporting times, closing the 27.6-minute gap between first click and first report.

What are the latest phishing trends for 2026?

The three biggest phishing trends in 2026 are: (1) AI-generated phishing now accounts for 82.6% of detected phishing emails, with 54% click rates matching human experts; (2) multi-channel attacks — vishing surged 442%, smishing grew 40%, QR phishing increased 400%; (3) BEC remains the costliest variant at \$4.67M average per attack, with volume surging 54% in H1 2025. Traditional email-only defenses are increasingly insufficient.

What is business email compromise (BEC)?

BEC is a form of phishing where attackers impersonate executives, vendors, or trusted contacts via email to trick employees into making wire transfers, sharing sensitive data, or changing payment details. FBI IC3 reported \$2.77 billion in BEC losses from 21,442 complaints in 2024. The average BEC attack costs \$4.67 million (IBM 2025). BEC requires no malware — just convincing impersonation, now supercharged by AI-generated content.

What is the best protection against phishing?

The most effective phishing defense combines multiple layers: (1) phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2/passkeys) — defeats even AitM attacks; (2) security awareness training with monthly simulations — reduces susceptibility to under 5%; (3) AI-based email gateway filtering; (4) URL sandboxing and real-time link analysis; (5) automated incident response for rapid credential reset after compromise. No single control stops all phishing — layered defense is essential.

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